editor with INDIA TODAY, bluntly stated, "Made in Japan—For Now". Initially, even complete cars and sub-assemblies were imported to meet deadlines, with indigenisation promised later. Yet the impact was immediate. Priced far below existing models, the Maruti 800 offered unprecedented fuel efficiency and reliability, quickly becoming "the hope of virtually the country's entire middle class".

Maruti's success didn't just reshape the Indian automobile industry. Long waiting lists and queues turned the car into a status symbol, signalling a new consumer aspiration. From a troubled dream to a mass phenomenon, Maruti did more than make cars—it changed how India moved, and how it imagined modern life. ■

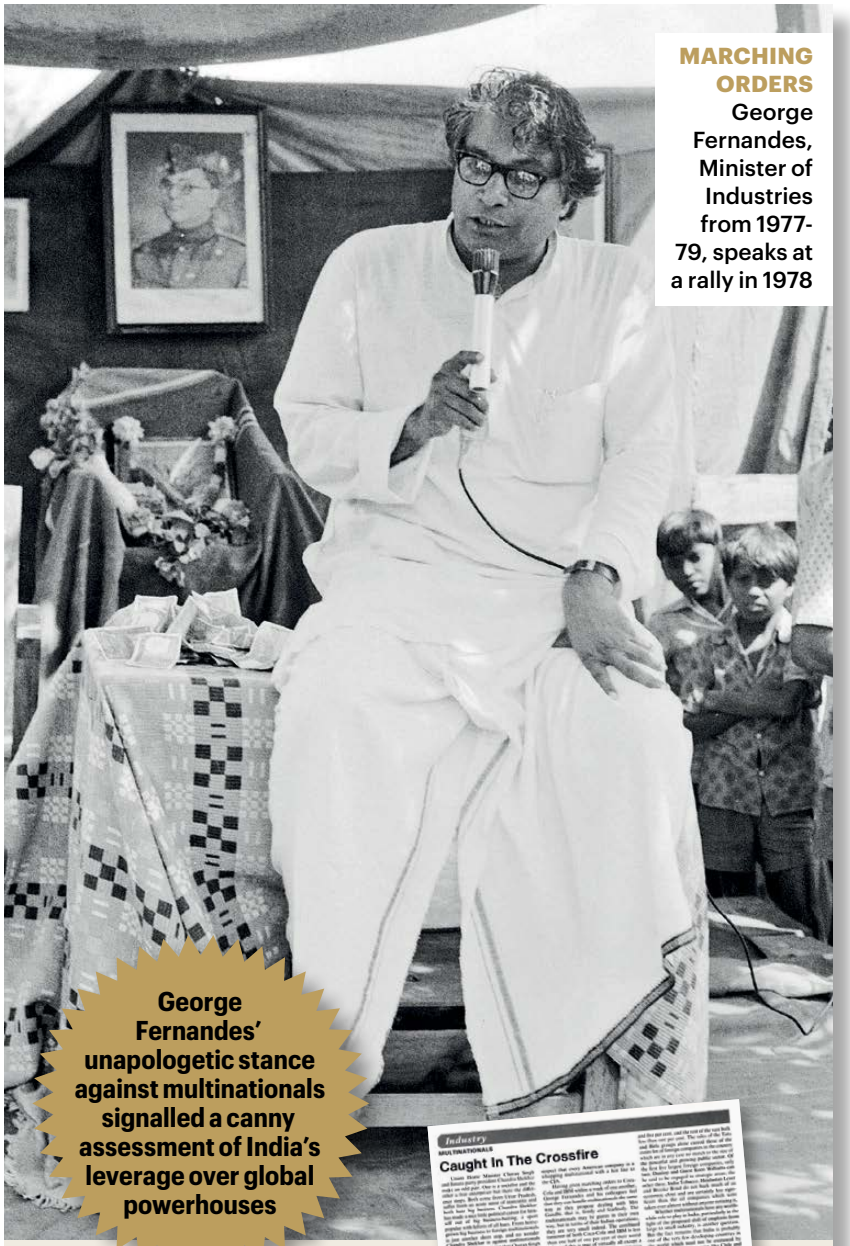


R.C. BHARGAVA
Chairman, Maruti Suzuki

"The Indian consumer's voice could not be suppressed"

Nobody in 1980s India dreamt that a tragic air accident would trigger an automobile revolution, and one day lead Maruti to ranking eighth globally among carmakers by market capitalisation. Back then, our first step was persuading the government to agree to a market survey, and to decide that Maruti would make small cars instead of the Renault 18. Osamu Suzuki, a true believer in the future of India, and I provided leadership for the next 40 years. His role as a teacher was pivotal to our success. Despite the government treating cars as low priority and taxing them heavily, sales and demand continued to grow. The Indian consumer's voice could not be suppressed. During the first decade, none of us ever thought of what the future could be. We set short-term goals and worked to achieve them, remembering Osamu-*san*'s direction that quality and cost had to keep improving all the time. We still remember and follow that eternally valid advice.

INDIA TODAY ARCHIVES



MARCHING ORDERS George Fernandes, Minister of Industries from 1977-79, speaks at a rally in 1978

George Fernandes' unapologetic stance against multinationals signalled a canny assessment of India's leverage over global powerhouses



Industry
MULTINATIONALS
Caught In The Crossfire

Multinationals: Caught in the Crossfire
INDIA TODAY, *Oct. 15, 1977*

"Having given marching orders to Coca-Cola and IBM within a week of one another, George Fernandes and his colleagues feel that they can handle multinationals the same way as they propose dealing with Mrs Gandhi, that is, firmly and fearlessly. The multinationals may be giants in their own way, but in terms of their Indian operations, they are very small indeed. The combined turnover of both Coca-Cola and IBM is less than one half of one per cent of their world sales and this is true of virtually all except a couple of the largest foreign companies operating in India.... The fact remains that India is probably one of the few developing countries in the world which need not be overawed by the foreign giants."